A CM WHO MEANS BUSINESS

Committed to development for all, Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin's firm hand at the helm ensures that his state stays at the top

By RAJ CHENGAPPA & AMARNATH K. MENON

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Like everything else about Muthuvel Karunanidhi Stalin, his house in the heart of Chennai, too, is understated. He chose not to shift to the chief minister's official residence after coming to power in May 2021, preferring instead to stay on in his elegant two-storeyed bungalow off Mount Road where security for visitors is discreet. Upstairs is a multi-purpose gym that Stalin likes to visit early every morning, combining weight training with yoga and meditation sessions to keep fit. You will find him most often in a spotless white *veshti* and bush shirt that has one distinguishing feature—the tall, unbuttoned spearpoint collar that contrasts well with his puffed jet-black hairdo.

In much the same way as Prince Charles, now the king of England, the 69-year-old Stalin also had to wait an eternity as heir apparent before he could become the chief minister of Tamil Nadu. His father, the late M. Karunanidhi, was the longest-serving chief minister of the state with five stints in office, the first when Stalin was just 16 years old. It was only in his final term that Stalin—named after the Soviet dictator who died in the same week in which he was born, in 1953—was made deputy chief minister between 2009 and 2011. Before that, like all the others, he too had to work his way through the ranks of his party, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). His first brush with power came when he was elected mayor of Chennai, the capital of the state and its most powerful city, in 1996 and earned plaudits for improving its infrastructure and cleanliness. And that's what Stalin says his father taught him: "work, work and work" and leave no stone unturned to achieve your objective.

It was only after Karunanidhi died in 2018 that Stalin came into his own, and assumed the reins of the DMK. He proved his mettle soon enough when the party-led front won 38 of the state's 39 seats in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, at a time when the Narendra Modi wave was at its peak. And those political credentials were firmly burnished in the May 2021 assembly election, when the DMK-led front won an impressive 159 of the total 234 seats. Election won, Stalin had to attend to the task of governance. But soon after taking over as chief minister, Covid-19 struck in its deadliest avatar and he found his hands full ensuring hospital care for the ailing and implementing an ambitious vaccination programme. It was, however, to be annus horribilis for Tamil Nadu, as floods ravaged the state towards the end of the year and Stalin had to marshal all the state's resources again to provide relief and rehabilitation for the flood-affected.

UNLIKE HIS PREDECESSORS, STALIN SHUNS SYCOPHANCY, IS A PATIENT LISTENER AND IS FOCUSED ON IMPLEMENTATION